great naqqaras, or kettledrums, whose doleful bass reverberations proclaimed the comings and goings of the rana. The royal library of Chittor was destroyed, too, its manuscripts reduced to ashes.

During his three days in Chittor, Akbar rewarded the bravest fighters. One of the men thus singled out for his exemplary service was a khatri, one Rai Rayan, who had begun his career as an accountant in the elephant stables.[*] Akbar then set off on foot in the rising heat of March to offer thanks for his great victory at the dargah at Ajmer, accompanied by some of the harem women and his closest courtiers, also on foot. At Ajmer, Akbar issued a Fathnama-i Chittor, a letter of victory, to be sent to the officers in the Punjab. In language full of bombast, the defeat of Chittor was stridently proclaimed to be the victory of Islam over infidels. In his fathnama, Akbar declared:

> We, as far as it is within our power, remain busy in jihad… we have succeeded in occupying a number of forts and towns belonging to the infidels and have established Islam there. With the help of our bloodthirsty sword we have erased the signs of infidelity from their minds and have destroyed temples in those places and also all over Hindustan.

Babur, after his famous victory over Rana Sangha at Khanua, similarly evoked the image of the Ghazi conqueror and, like Akbar, would quietly put it aside with equal nonchalance once it had served its purpose. Moreover, Iqtidar Alam Khan has argued that a lot of this overtly orthodox posturing, like the fathnama and the visible deference to the sadr, Shaikh Abd un-Nabi, were in fact a calculated move by Akbar to appeal to the Indian shaikhzadas. In any event, as we will see later, this was a path that was soon forsaken, quietly assigned to past mistakes and experiments. Akbar would understand the need for a much more robust and inclusive idea of empire, one that would truly reflect and incorporate the multiple identities of Hindustan.

After the defeat of Chittor, Akbar remained in Ajmer for ten days before returning to Agra. After the capitulation of what was considered one of the mightiest fortresses of Hindustan, Akbar was now ready to attack Ranthambore. To be able to subdue the entire province of Rajasthan it would be crucial to take its great fortresses, eloquent symbols of its invincibility.